

Below is a research-backed breakdown of the main workout philosophies and splits for **weight loss, muscle gain, aesthetics, strength, and cardio/endurance**.

The biggest thing that showed up across the sources: there is no magical split. The split is just the weekly organization. The real drivers are **specificity, progressive overload, total weekly volume, intensity, recovery, and consistency**.

1. Universal Training Principles

The non-negotiables

1. Specificity

Train the thing you want to improve.

If the goal is strength, heavy compound lifts need to be prioritized. If the goal is endurance, aerobic volume matters. If the goal is muscle growth, enough weekly hard sets per muscle group matter. ACSM's 2026 resistance training update explicitly separates recommendations by outcome, noting that strength, hypertrophy, and power are optimized by adjusting load, volume, and execution style.

2. Progressive overload

The body adapts when training stress gradually rises. This can mean more weight, more reps, more sets, better range of motion, better technique, shorter rest for conditioning, or longer duration for endurance.

3. Volume matters, but only if you recover

For hypertrophy, ACSM's 2026 guidance points to roughly **10 or more weekly sets per muscle group** as a useful target. Other reviews suggest many lifters may benefit from a broader range around **12 to 20 sets per muscle group per week**, especially as they become more trained.

4. Intensity has to match the goal

For strength, heavy loads matter. ACSM's 2026 update recommends around **80 percent or more of 1RM** for strength-focused work. For hypertrophy, moderate loads like **60 to 80 percent of 1RM** and rep ranges around **8 to 12** are still widely supported, though muscle can be built across a wider rep range if sets are taken close enough to failure.

5. Proximity to failure matters more for muscle than strength

A 2024 meta-regression found that hypertrophy appears to improve as sets are taken closer to failure, while strength gains are less dependent on training to failure. In practical terms: for muscle growth, most hard sets should probably end around **0 to 3 reps in reserve**. For strength, you can often leave more reps in the tank and still get stronger, especially on heavy technical lifts.

6. Cardio and lifting should both exist for most people

CDC, AHA, and ACSM guidance all still support the same baseline: adults should get about **150 minutes per week of moderate aerobic activity**, or **75 minutes vigorous**, plus at least **2 days of muscle-strengthening work**.

2. Weight Loss / Fat Loss

Core philosophy

Weight loss is not mainly a workout split problem. It is an **energy balance problem** supported by training.

The best workout plan for weight loss does three things:

1. Burns calories without crushing recovery.
2. Preserves or builds muscle while dieting.
3. Improves adherence so the person can keep going.

The current research still supports aerobic activity as useful for reducing body fat and waist circumference. A 2024 systematic review and dose-response meta-analysis found that aerobic exercise of at least **150 minutes per week** was associated with clinically meaningful reductions in waist circumference and body fat measures.

ACSM's older but still-cited position stand found that **150 to 250 minutes per week** of moderate-intensity physical activity produces modest weight loss, while **more than 250 minutes per week** is associated with more clinically significant weight loss and better weight maintenance.

Best training emphasis

For fat loss, the most reliable structure is:

Resistance training 2 to 4 days per week

plus

Cardio 2 to 5 days per week

plus

daily steps / low-intensity movement

Resistance training is crucial because dieting can reduce lean mass. Reviews on weight-loss-related muscle loss emphasize that preserving muscle matters for function, metabolism, and long-term outcomes.

Best splits for weight loss

Option A: 3-day full-body split

Best for beginners, busy people, people with higher body fat, and people who need simplicity.

Example week

Day	Workout
Monday	Full body strength
Tuesday	Zone 2 cardio / incline walk
Wednesday	Full body strength
Thursday	Cardio or steps
Friday	Full body strength
Saturday	Longer walk, bike, swim, sport
Sunday	Rest or easy movement

Why it works:

Full-body training hits each major muscle group multiple times per week while leaving room for cardio and recovery.

Option B: 4-day upper/lower split

Best for intermediate people who want fat loss while maintaining or building muscle.

Day	Workout
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Monday	Upper body
Tuesday	Lower body
Wednesday	Zone 2 cardio
Thursday	Upper body
Friday	Lower body
Saturday	Cardio, intervals, or long walk
Sunday	Rest

Why it works:

It gives enough lifting frequency to preserve muscle while allowing cardio to be inserted without turning every session into a marathon.

Option C: 2-day lifting + 3-day cardio

Best for people who mainly need weight loss, heart health, and habit-building.

Day	Workout
Monday	Full body strength
Tuesday	Cardio
Wednesday	Cardio or steps
Thursday	Full body strength
Friday	Cardio
Weekend	Long walk, sport, hike, recovery

Why it works:

This aligns closely with public health guidance: at least 2 days of muscle-strengthening plus 150 minutes of aerobic activity weekly.

What to avoid

Avoid making every workout a brutal HIIT session. HIIT can help, but it is fatiguing. ACSM has noted HIIT can improve insulin sensitivity, blood pressure, and body composition similarly to moderate-intensity continuous training, but that does not mean more HIIT is always better.

For most fat-loss plans, use HIIT **1 to 2 times per week max**, then build the rest around lifting, walking, and sustainable cardio.

3. Muscle Gain / Hypertrophy

Core philosophy

Muscle gain is driven by:

1. Enough hard weekly sets.
2. Exercises that create high muscle tension.
3. Progressive overload.
4. Training close enough to failure.
5. Food, protein, and recovery.

ACSM's 2026 guidance says hypertrophy should focus on higher weekly volume, roughly **10 sets per muscle group per week**.

A 2022 systematic review suggests **12 to 20 weekly sets per muscle group** may be a strong general target for maximizing hypertrophy, though beginners can grow on less and advanced lifters may need more careful volume distribution.

ISSN's protein position stand states that **1.4 to 2.0 grams of protein per kilogram of body weight per day** is sufficient for most exercising individuals to build or maintain muscle.

Rep ranges

The classic hypertrophy zone is still useful:

6 to 12 reps for many compound and machine movements

10 to 20 reps for accessories and isolation work

15 to 30 reps can work for some movements if taken close to failure

Schoenfeld's 2021 review found moderate loads around **60 to 80 percent of 1RM** and **8 to 12 reps per set** are effective for hypertrophy.

Best splits for muscle gain

Option A: 3-day full-body hypertrophy

Best for beginners and early intermediates.

Day	Focus
Monday	Full body, squat emphasis
Wednesday	Full body, press emphasis
Friday	Full body, hinge / pull emphasis

Why it works:

Each muscle gets stimulated 2 to 3 times per week. It is simple, recoverable, and efficient.

Option B: 4-day upper/lower

Best all-around hypertrophy split for most people.

Day	Focus
Monday	Upper body
Tuesday	Lower body
Thursday	Upper body
Friday	Lower body

Why it works:

It gives every major muscle group 2 direct sessions per week, which makes it easy to distribute 10 to 20 weekly sets without doing junk volume.

Option C: 5-day upper/lower/push/pull/legs

Best for intermediate lifters who want more volume.

Day	Focus
Monday	Upper

Tuesday	Lower
Wednesday	Rest or cardio
Thursday	Push
Friday	Pull
Saturday	Legs
Sunday	Rest

Why it works:

This gives more weekly volume and lets you bias weak points without every session being too long.

Option D: 6-day push/pull/legs

Best for advanced lifters with good sleep, food, and recovery.

Day	Focus
Monday	Push
Tuesday	Pull
Wednesday	Legs
Thursday	Push
Friday	Pull
Saturday	Legs
Sunday	Rest

Why it works:

High frequency, high volume, clear organization.

Downside:

Recovery can become the limiting factor fast. If performance drops, joints hurt, or pumps disappear, volume is too high.

Option E: Body-part / bro split

Best for advanced bodybuilding-style training, not beginners.

Day	Focus
Monday	Chest
Tuesday	Back
Wednesday	Legs
Thursday	Shoulders
Friday	Arms
Saturday	Weak point
Sunday	Rest

Why it works:

It allows high per-session volume and deep focus.

Downside:

Each muscle may only get trained once per week unless the plan is designed carefully. Research on training frequency suggests frequency can help hypertrophy, but its biggest practical role is often helping distribute weekly volume.

4. Aesthetics

Core philosophy

Aesthetics is not a separate physiological adaptation. It is a combination of:

1. Muscle gain in the right places.
2. Fat loss enough to reveal shape.
3. Posture, symmetry, and proportions.
4. A sustainable plan that does not wreck recovery.

Aesthetic training is basically **hypertrophy training with visual prioritization**.

For men, this often means emphasis on:

- Shoulders
- Upper chest
- Lats
- Arms
- Quads
- Hamstrings
- Calves
- A smaller waist through fat loss, not endless ab work

For women, depending on preference, this often means emphasis on:

- Glutes
- Hamstrings
- Quads
- Shoulders
- Back
- Core control

The underlying hypertrophy rules still apply: enough weekly sets, progressive overload, and hard sets close enough to failure.

Best splits for aesthetics

Option A: Upper/lower with aesthetic bias

Best for most people.

Day	Focus
Monday	Upper, shoulder/back emphasis
Tuesday	Lower, glute/quad emphasis
Thursday	Upper, chest/arms emphasis
Friday	Lower, hamstring/glute emphasis
Saturday	Optional cardio or weak point

Why it works:

Balanced, recoverable, and easy to bias certain muscles.

Option B: Push/pull/legs with weak-point work

Best for intermediates.

Day	Focus
Monday	Push, upper chest/shoulders
Tuesday	Pull, lats/rear delts
Wednesday	Legs, glutes/quads
Thursday	Rest
Friday	Push, shoulders/arms
Saturday	Pull, back width/arms
Sunday	Legs or cardio

Why it works:

Aesthetic programs usually need more volume for visual muscles like side delts, lats, upper chest, arms, glutes, and calves.

Option C: 5-day physique split

Best for people who want a bodybuilding-style look.

Day	Focus
Monday	Chest + side delts
Tuesday	Back + rear delts
Wednesday	Legs
Thursday	Shoulders + arms
Friday	Glutes/hamstrings or weak points
Saturday	Zone 2 cardio
Sunday	Rest

Aesthetic training rules

Rule 1: Train compounds first, then sculpt

Start with the big tension-producing lifts, then add isolation work.

Example upper day:

- Incline press
- Pull-up or pulldown
- Row
- Shoulder press
- Lateral raise
- Rear delt fly
- Curl
- Triceps extension

Rule 2: Don't confuse sweating with shaping

Aesthetic change comes from muscle gain and fat loss, not just burning yourself out.

Rule 3: Use cardio strategically

Cardio helps fat loss and health, but too much hard cardio can interfere with lower-body recovery. Most aesthetic plans do best with **2 to 4 Zone 2 sessions per week** plus steps.

5. Strength

Core philosophy

Strength is the ability to produce force in specific movements.

Strength training needs:

1. Heavy loads.
2. Skill practice on the main lifts.
3. Longer rest.
4. Lower reps.
5. Planned progression.
6. Less failure than hypertrophy training.

ACSM's 2026 update recommends heavy loads around **80 percent or more of 1RM** for strength, with roughly **2 to 3 sets per exercise** as a key evidence-based reference point.

Older ACSM progression guidance, still widely cited, recommends training frequency of **2 to 3 days per week for novices**, **3 to 4 days for intermediates**, and **4 to 5 days for advanced lifters**.

Strength rep ranges

Common strength zones:

Goal	Reps
Max strength	1 to 5
Strength + size	4 to 8
Technique practice	2 to 5
Accessories	6 to 15

Strength does not require constant failure. In fact, taking heavy squats, deadlifts, and bench presses to failure too often usually creates too much fatigue and technical breakdown.

Best splits for strength

Option A: 3-day full-body strength

Best for beginners and early intermediates.

Day	Focus
Monday	Squat + bench + row
Wednesday	Deadlift + overhead press + pull-up
Friday	Squat variation + bench variation + hinge accessory

Why it works:

Frequent practice improves skill. The lifts are repeated often enough to learn them.

Option B: 4-day upper/lower strength

Best for intermediate strength.

Day	Focus
Monday	Upper strength
Tuesday	Lower strength
Thursday	Upper volume
Friday	Lower volume

Why it works:

You get heavy practice and enough accessory volume to build the muscles supporting the main lifts.

Option C: Powerlifting split

Best for squat, bench, deadlift strength.

Day	Focus
Monday	Squat + bench
Tuesday	Deadlift + posterior chain
Thursday	Bench + upper back
Friday	Squat/deadlift variation + accessories

Why it works:

It is specific. You train the competition lifts or close variations often.

Option D: 5-day strength specialization

Best for advanced lifters.

Day	Focus
Monday	Heavy squat

Tuesday	Heavy bench
Wednesday	Deadlift
Thursday	Bench volume
Friday	Squat variation + accessories

Why it works:

It spreads fatigue across the week and allows more focused technical work.

Strength training rules

Rule 1: Main lift first

Heavy, technical lifts should be done early in the session while fresh. ACSM's 2026 summary also emphasizes doing strength exercises earlier in the session.

Rule 2: Rest longer

For heavy work, longer rest supports performance. ACSM materials commonly recommend **2 to 3 minutes** for heavier, higher-intensity exercises, and a 2023 review found **3 to 4 minutes** effective between sets for high-intensity strength training in trained adults.

Rule 3: Use accessories to fix weak links

Accessories should support the main lifts.

Examples:

- Weak bench lockout: triceps, close-grip bench, board press
- Weak squat position: quads, bracing, upper back
- Weak deadlift off floor: hamstrings, quads, positioning
- Weak deadlift lockout: glutes, hip hinge, back strength

6. Cardio / Endurance

Core philosophy

Endurance is built by accumulating aerobic work while strategically adding intensity.

The modern endurance world still uses these major models:

1. Zone 2 / aerobic base training
2. Polarized training
3. Pyramidal training
4. Threshold training
5. HIIT / interval training
6. Long slow distance

Public-health guidance remains that adults should get **150 minutes moderate aerobic activity** or **75 minutes vigorous activity** weekly, with more benefits from doing more.

Zone 2 training

Zone 2 is low-to-moderate intensity aerobic work. It should feel sustainable and conversational.

AHA describes moderate intensity as around **50 to 70 percent of max heart rate**, and vigorous as around **70 to 85 percent**.

Zone 2 is popular because it builds aerobic capacity with relatively low fatigue. For general fitness, this could be incline walking, easy jogging, cycling, rowing, swimming, or hiking.

Polarized training

Polarized training means most training is easy, some is very hard, and relatively little is in the middle.

A 2024 systematic review and meta-analysis found polarized training was superior to other training intensity distributions for improving VO2 peak, especially in shorter interventions and highly trained athletes, though not always superior for every endurance outcome.

A practical polarized model:

- 80 percent easy
- 20 percent hard

This is not a law, but it is a common endurance framework.

Pyramidal training

Pyramidal training means most work is easy, some is moderate, and a small amount is hard.

This often looks like:

- Most time in easy aerobic zones
- Some tempo / threshold work
- Small amount of high-intensity intervals

This is common for runners, cyclists, and triathletes because it builds a large aerobic base while still practicing race-relevant moderate efforts.

HIIT

HIIT is useful, but it is not the whole endurance plan.

HIIT improves fitness efficiently and can improve cardiometabolic markers, but it creates more fatigue per minute than easy cardio. ACSM notes HIIT can improve insulin sensitivity, blood pressure, and body composition comparably to moderate-intensity continuous training.

Best splits for cardio/endurance

Option A: General health cardio split

Day	Workout
Monday	Zone 2, 30 to 45 min
Wednesday	Zone 2, 30 to 45 min
Friday	Intervals, 15 to 25 min
Saturday	Long easy cardio, 45 to 90 min

Option B: Beginner running split

Day	Workout
Monday	Easy run/walk
Wednesday	Easy run/walk
Friday	Short intervals or hills
Sunday	Longer easy run/walk

Option C: 80/20 endurance split

Day	Workout
Monday	Easy Zone 2
Tuesday	Intervals
Wednesday	Easy Zone 2
Thursday	Rest or strength
Friday	Easy Zone 2
Saturday	Tempo or intervals
Sunday	Long Zone 2

Option D: Hybrid endurance + lifting

Day	Workout
Monday	Strength lower
Tuesday	Zone 2
Wednesday	Strength upper
Thursday	Intervals
Friday	Full body strength
Saturday	Long Zone 2
Sunday	Rest

7. Goal-by-Goal Split Recommendations

Weight loss

Best splits:

1. **3-day full body + 3 cardio days**
2. **4-day upper/lower + 2 cardio days**
3. **2-day full body + 3 to 5 cardio/step days**

Best philosophy:

- Calorie deficit
- Lift to preserve muscle
- Cardio to increase energy expenditure and health
- Steps for low-fatigue calorie burn
- HIIT sparingly

Best weekly target:

- 2 to 4 lifting sessions
- 150 to 300 minutes cardio depending on goal and recovery
- 7,000 to 12,000 steps per day if tolerated

Muscle gain

Best splits:

1. **3-day full body**
2. **4-day upper/lower**
3. **5-day upper/lower/push/pull/legs**
4. **6-day push/pull/legs**

Best philosophy:

- Progressive overload
- 10 to 20 hard sets per muscle weekly
- 0 to 3 reps in reserve on most hypertrophy work
- Protein 1.4 to 2.0 g/kg/day
- Sleep and calorie surplus or maintenance

Best weekly target:

- 3 to 6 lifting sessions
- Each muscle trained 2x weekly for most people
- Cardio 1 to 3x weekly for health, not so much that it hurts recovery

Aesthetics

Best splits:

1. **4-day upper/lower with aesthetic bias**
2. **5-day physique split**
3. **PPL with weak-point specialization**

Best philosophy:

- Build visual muscles
- Keep waist lean through nutrition and cardio
- Prioritize shoulders, lats, upper chest, arms, glutes, legs depending on desired look
- Avoid random workouts
- Use photos, measurements, and strength logs

Best weekly target:

- 4 to 5 lifting sessions
- 2 to 4 cardio sessions
- 10 to 20 sets for priority muscles
- 6 to 12 sets for maintenance muscles

Strength

Best splits:

1. **3-day full-body strength**
2. **4-day upper/lower strength**
3. **4-day powerlifting split**
4. **5-day advanced strength split**

Best philosophy:

- Heavy loads
- Main lifts first
- Lower reps
- Longer rests
- Practice technique
- Avoid frequent failure on heavy compounds

Best weekly target:

- 3 to 5 lifting sessions
- Main lifts 1 to 3 times weekly depending on level
- Heavy work around 80 percent or more of 1RM
- Accessories after main lifts

Cardio / endurance

Best splits:

1. **3-day beginner cardio**
2. **4-day general fitness cardio**
3. **80/20 endurance split**
4. **Hybrid strength + endurance split**

Best philosophy:

- Build aerobic base
- Most work easy
- Hard intervals limited and purposeful
- Long sessions build durability
- Strength work supports joints, posture, and performance

Best weekly target:

- 150 minutes minimum for health
- 3 to 6 cardio sessions for endurance progress
- 1 to 2 hard sessions weekly
- Most training easy enough to recover from

8. The Practical “Best Split” Matrix

Goal	Beginner	Intermediate	Advanced
Weight loss	3x full body + walking/cardio	4x upper/lower + cardio	4 to 5x lifting + programmed cardio
Muscle gain	3x full body	4x upper/lower	5 to 6x PPL or specialization
Aesthetics	3x full body + weak-point accessories	4x upper/lower aesthetic bias	5x physique split
Strength	3x full body strength	4x upper/lower strength	4 to 5x powerlifting/periodized
Endurance	3x cardio + 2x strength	4 to 5x cardio + 2x strength	5 to 7x cardio with intensity distribution

9. What People Are Still Actually Using

Based on current guidelines and recent reviews, these approaches are still very much alive and evidence-compatible:

Still useful

- Full-body training
- Upper/lower split
- Push/pull/legs
- Body-part splits for advanced physique goals
- Zone 2 cardio
- 80/20 or polarized endurance training
- Pyramidal endurance training
- HIIT, used sparingly
- Strength blocks with heavy compound lifts
- Hypertrophy blocks with higher weekly volume

Overrated or misused

- “Fat-burning workouts” that ignore nutrition
 - Daily HIIT
 - Random WOD-style training for every goal
 - Bro splits for beginners
 - Training to failure on every set
 - Cardio-only weight loss plans with no resistance training
 - Strength plans that never go heavy
 - Aesthetic plans with no progression tracking
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10. MVP App-Friendly Goal Categories

For your app, I would structure goals like this:

1. Fat Loss

Primary outcome: lose fat while keeping muscle
Training: full-body or upper/lower + cardio + steps
Metrics: weight trend, waist, photos, workout consistency, steps

2. Muscle Gain

Primary outcome: gain size and strength
Training: hypertrophy split, progressive overload
Metrics: bodyweight trend, measurements, lift progression, photos

3. Aesthetic Recomposition

Primary outcome: look leaner, more defined, more proportional
Training: hypertrophy with weak-point emphasis + cardio
Metrics: photos, waist, shoulders/chest/glutes/arms measurements, weight trend

4. Strength

Primary outcome: increase major lifts
Training: squat/bench/deadlift/press focused
Metrics: estimated 1RM, top sets, volume PRs, form videos

5. Cardio / Endurance

Primary outcome: improve stamina and conditioning
Training: Zone 2 base + intervals + optional strength
Metrics: resting HR, pace, distance, duration, heart-rate zones, perceived effort

6. Athletic Performance

This is the “other option” I would add.

Primary outcome: move better, jump higher, sprint faster, perform better
Training: strength + power + mobility + conditioning
Metrics: sprint time, jump, agility, strength, conditioning tests

Bottom Line

For the app, do **not** build programs around trendy split names first.

Build around the user's goal:

- **Fat loss:** preserve muscle, increase movement, manage calories.
- **Muscle gain:** volume, progressive overload, protein, recovery.
- **Aesthetics:** hypertrophy plus fat-loss control and weak-point targeting.
- **Strength:** heavy specific lifts, skill practice, longer rest, lower reps.
- **Endurance:** mostly easy aerobic work plus strategic intensity.
- **Athletic:** strength, power, conditioning, mobility, and skill transfer.

Then assign the split based on their schedule, experience level, recovery, equipment, and goal. That is how the plan becomes personalized instead of just another generic "PPL" or "fat loss workout."